

BINDING — Selection is its own step (Charles lock, Jul 2026)

Status: Binding for agents, re-entry docs, basketball v1, and manuscript framing.
Charles #1 confusion resolved: Do **not** merge “describe the peer environment” with “who wins the scarce slot.”

The two mechanisms (keep separate)

Environment / development		Selection (advancement rule)
Question	How do peers affect net value, learning, visibility?	Who gets the draft pick / promotion / slot?
Symbols (theory)	$L_{net} = B(\cdot) - D(\cdot)$ — benefit minus congestion in the environment	$S_i = A_i - \lambda \cdot L_C$ — Alex score: ability minus congestion in who gets selected
What it is NOT	The full story of who gets drafted	The same as fitting the hero curve
Layer A hero	Shows outcome (draft rate vs pool quality)	Does not tell you environment vs selection channel
Layer C sim	Roster assignment (who lands where)	Explicit step: rank by selection score → top K

One sentence: The hero describes outcomes; Alex’s equation describes **who gets selected**; the sim tests whether congestion in the **selection rule** changes who gets selected.

Why Charles (and others) get lost

The project uses **B – D** language for the **environment** and **Alex’s score** for **selection**. If you treat them as one blob (“the model”), you rebuild a complicated world where everything happens at once.

- v1 simplification:
- **B – D** = prose frame for help vs hurt among peers (not separately estimated in v1).
 - **Alex score = selection only** — congestion enters the **advancement rule**, not “the whole economy.”
 - **538D** = make **selection** a visible step: talent-only vs talent-minus-congestion knockout.

What each layer owns

Layer	Owns
A	Empirical curve — <i>what</i> the data look like
B	Two-part story: (1) B vs D in environment; (2) D (congestion) may enter selection via Alex score
C	Code: assignment → selection score → top-K → plot

Agent rule

When explaining basketball model work to Charles or in manuscript prose:

- 1. Say **selection** when you mean draft rule / Alex score / top-K.
- 2. Say **environment** when you mean B – D / peer effects on development.
- 3. Never imply the hero regression **is** the selection equation.
- 4. Layer C knockouts are about **selection ingredients**, not reproducing every environmental channel.

Re-entry pointer: [re_entry/02_Three_Kinds_of_Model.md](#) § “Selection is its own step”.